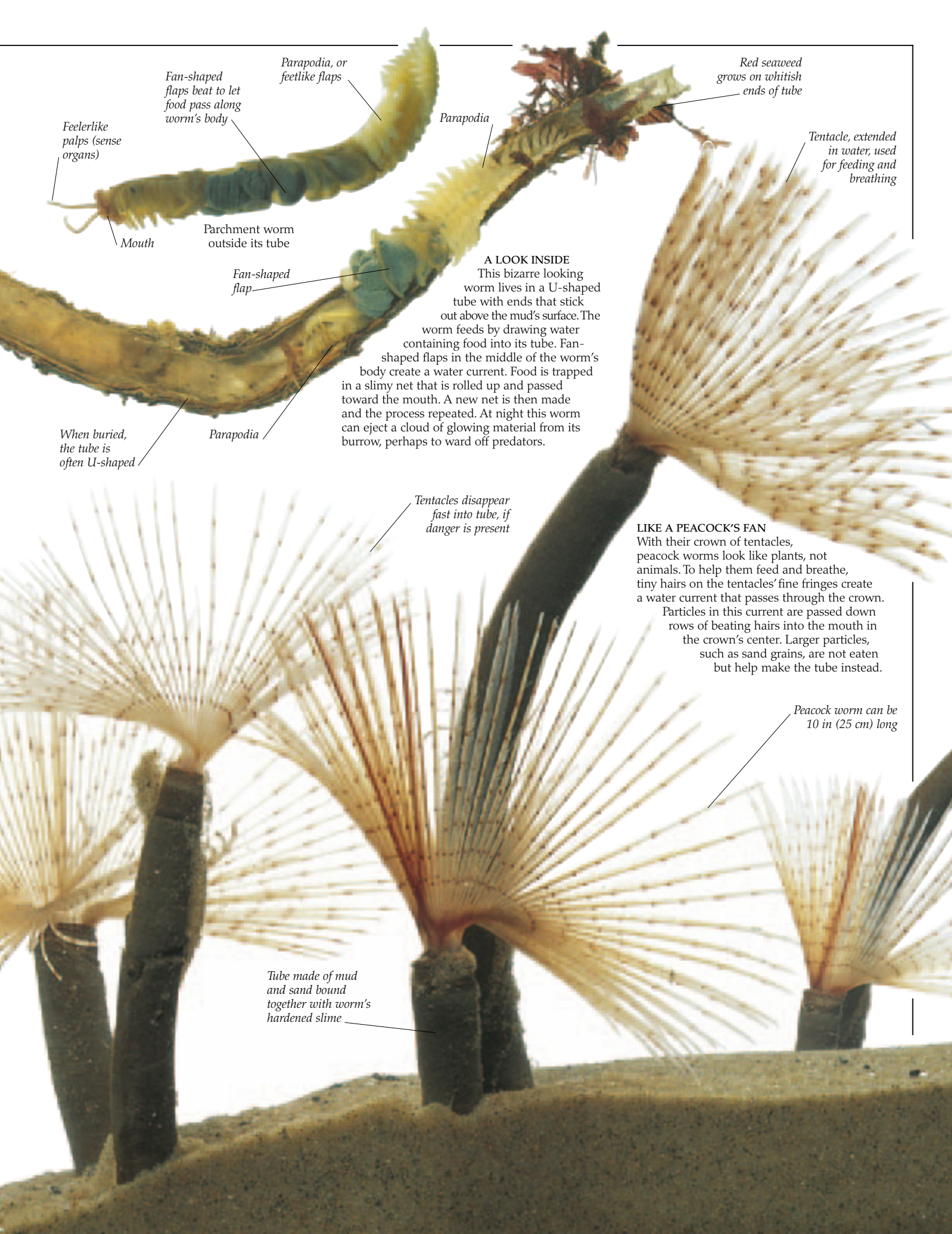




Feelerlike
palps (sense
organs)

Fan-shaped
flaps beat to let
food pass along
worm's body

Parapodia, or
feetlike flaps

Parapodia

Red seaweed
grows on whitish
ends of tube

Tentacle, extended
in water, used
for feeding and
breathing

Mouth

Parchment worm
outside its tube

Fan-shaped
flap

A LOOK INSIDE

This bizarre looking worm lives in a U-shaped tube with ends that stick out above the mud's surface. The worm feeds by drawing water containing food into its tube. Fan-shaped flaps in the middle of the worm's body create a water current. Food is trapped in a slimy net that is rolled up and passed toward the mouth. A new net is then made and the process repeated. At night this worm can eject a cloud of glowing material from its burrow, perhaps to ward off predators.

When buried,
the tube is
often U-shaped

Parapodia

Tentacles disappear
fast into tube, if
danger is present

LIKE A PEACOCK'S FAN

With their crown of tentacles, peacock worms look like plants, not animals. To help them feed and breathe, tiny hairs on the tentacles' fine fringes create a water current that passes through the crown. Particles in this current are passed down rows of beating hairs into the mouth in the crown's center. Larger particles, such as sand grains, are not eaten but help make the tube instead.

Peacock worm can be
10 in (25 cm) long

Tube made of mud
and sand bound
together with worm's
hardened slime